

TPI Content Style Guide

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Overview

This guide defines content standards for all TPI portals, ensuring consistent, clear, and professional communication across all interfaces.

Microcopy Rules

Enterprise Tone

Voice Characteristics

- Professional: Clear, direct, authoritative
- Helpful: Guides users without condescension
- Concise: No unnecessary words
- Actionable: Every message has a purpose

Tone Examples

☒ **Good:**

- "Save changes to update the incident status"
- "No incidents found. Create your first incident to get started."
- "Failed to load data. Please check your connection and try again."

☒ **Avoid:**

- "Oops! Something went wrong!" (too casual)
- "You don't have any incidents yet, but that's okay!" (too chatty)
- "Error 500: Internal Server Error" (too technical for users)

Button Labels

Action Verbs

- Use: Create, Save, Delete, Export, Cancel, Close
- Avoid: Submit, Click here, OK, Yes/No

Specificity

- ☒ "Save Changes" (specific)
- ☒ "Save" (ambiguous - save what?)

Destructive Actions

- Use: "Delete", "Remove", "Archive"
- Avoid: "Destroy", "Kill", "Remove Forever"

Form Labels

Clarity

- ☒ "Incident Title" (clear)
- ☒ "Title" (ambiguous)

Required Fields

- Indicate: Asterisk (*) + "Required" in help text
- Format: "Field Name *"

Help Text

- Position: Below field
- Length: 1-2 sentences max
- Purpose: Explain why or how, not what

Error Copy Standards

Error Message Structure

Format:

1. What happened (user-friendly)
2. Why it happened (if helpful)
3. What to do next (actionable)

Example:

```
Failed to save incident.  
The server is temporarily unavailable.  
Please try again in a few moments.
```

Error Types

Network Errors

- Message: "Failed to load data. Please check your connection and try again."
- Action: Retry button
- Tone: Helpful, not blaming

Validation Errors

- Message: "Please correct the errors below and try again."
- Location: Inline with fields

- Format: Specific field error + general summary

Permission Errors

- Message: "You don't have permission to perform this action."
- Action: "Request Access" button (if applicable)
- Tone: Professional, not apologetic

404 Errors

- Message: "Page not found. The page you're looking for doesn't exist."
- Action: "Go to Dashboard" button
- Helpful: Suggest common pages

500 Errors

- Message: "Something went wrong on our end. We've been notified and are working on it."
- Action: Retry button
- Tone: Reassuring, transparent

Error Message Guidelines

- Do:** ☒ Use plain language
☒ Provide actionable guidance
☒ Show error at point of action
☒ Include error code (collapsed) for support

- Don't:** ☒ Show technical stack traces
☒ Use jargon or technical terms
☒ Blame the user
☒ Leave user without next steps
-

Status Naming Conventions

Status Values

Standard Statuses

Active/Inactive

- Active: Entity is operational/enabled
- Inactive: Entity is disabled/paused
- Use for: Services, features, users

Pending/In Progress/Completed

- Pending: Waiting to start
- In Progress: Currently being worked on
- Completed: Finished successfully
- Use for: Tasks, workflows, approvals

Open/Resolved/Closed

- Open: Issue is active
- Resolved: Issue is fixed
- Closed: Issue is archived
- Use for: Incidents, tickets, issues

Draft/Published/Archived

- Draft: Not yet published
- Published: Live and visible
- Archived: No longer active
- Use for: Content, releases, documents

Status Badge Labels

Format

- Uppercase: All status labels
- Length: 2-3 words max
- Consistency: Same status = same label everywhere

Examples

- ☒ "ACTIVE", "IN PROGRESS", "RESOLVED"
- ✗ "Active", "in progress", "Resolved"

Color Mapping

- Green: Active, Completed, Resolved, Published
- Yellow: Pending, In Progress, Warning
- Red: Error, Failed, Critical, Closed
- Gray: Inactive, Draft, Archived, Cancelled

Date/Time Formatting Standards

Date Formats

Relative Time (for recent events)

- Format: "< 1 min ago", "2 hours ago", "3 days ago"
- Use when: Activity feeds, recent updates
- Threshold: Show relative for < 7 days, absolute for older

Absolute Date (for specific dates)

- Format: "Jan 15, 2025"
- Use when: Important dates, deadlines, creation dates

Date Range

- Format: "Jan 15 - Jan 20, 2025"
- Use when: Filters, reports, time periods

Time Formats

12-Hour Format (default)

- Format: "2:30 PM"
- Use when: User-facing times, timestamps

24-Hour Format (optional)

- Format: "14:30"
- Use when: Technical contexts, logs

Timezone

- Display: User's local timezone
- Indicate: "(Local Time)" if needed
- Convert: All times to user's timezone

Examples

Timestamps

- Recent: "2 hours ago"
- Today: "2:30 PM"
- This week: "Monday, 2:30 PM"
- Older: "Jan 15, 2025 2:30 PM"

Date Only

- Format: "Jan 15, 2025"
- Use: Creation dates, deadlines

Duration

- Format: "2h 30m", "3d 5h", "45s"
- Use: Processing times, elapsed time

Currency Formatting Standards

Format Rules

USD Format

- Symbol: \$ (prefix)
- Decimals: Always 2 decimal places
- Separators: Comma for thousands
- Format: **\$1,234.56**

Negative Values

- Format: **-\$123.45**
- Color: Red (for losses, negative changes)
- Indicate: Minus sign + red color

Zero Values

- Format: **\$0.00**
- Display: Always show, don't hide

Large Numbers

- Format: **\$1.2M** (millions), **\$45.6K** (thousands)
- Threshold: Abbreviate if > 10,000
- Precision: 1 decimal place for abbreviations

Examples

Standard Amounts

- **\$1,234.56**
- **\$0.50**
- **\$10,000.00**

Large Amounts

- **\$1.2M** (instead of \$1,200,000.00)
- **\$45.6K** (instead of \$45,600.00)

Negative Amounts

- **-\$123.45** (red color)
- **-\$1.2M** (red color)

Number Formatting Standards

Integer Formatting

Standard Integers

- Format: **1,234**
- Separator: Comma every 3 digits
- Use: Counts, quantities, IDs

Large Integers

- Format: **1.2M** (millions), **45.6K** (thousands)
- Threshold: Abbreviate if > 10,000
- Use: Large counts, metrics

Decimal Formatting

Standard Decimals

- Format: 1,234.56
- Decimals: 2 decimal places (default)
- Use: Percentages, ratios, measurements

Precision Decimals

- Format: 1,234.5678
- Decimals: As needed for precision
- Use: Technical metrics, calculations

Percentage Formatting

Standard Percentages

- Format: 45.6%
- Decimals: 1 decimal place (default)
- Use: Completion, rates, changes

Whole Percentages

- Format: 45%
- Decimals: 0 (when appropriate)
- Use: Simple percentages, whole numbers

Examples

Integers

- 1,234
- 12,345
- 1.2M (1,200,000)

Decimals

- 1,234.56
- 0.50
- 99.99

Percentages

- 45.6%
- 100%
- 0.5%

Empty State Messages

Message Structure

Format:

1. Title: "No [entities] found"

2. Description: Contextual help or explanation
3. Action: Primary CTA (if applicable)

Empty State Types

No Data

- Title: "No [entities] found"
- Description: "Get started by creating your first [entity]."
- Action: "Create [Entity]" button

Filtered Empty

- Title: "No results match your filters"
- Description: "Try adjusting your search criteria or clearing filters."
- Action: "Clear Filters" button

Permission Empty

- Title: "Access Restricted"
- Description: "You don't have permission to view [entities]. Contact your administrator for access."
- Action: "Request Access" button (if applicable)

Error Empty

- Title: "Unable to Load [Entities]"
- Description: "There was an error loading the data. Please try again."
- Action: "Retry" button

Examples

Good Empty States

```
Title: "No incidents found"
Description: "Get started by creating your first incident report."
Action: "New Incident" button
```

```
Title: "No results match your filters"
Description: "Try adjusting your search criteria or clearing all filters."
Action: "Clear Filters" button
```

Loading Messages

Loading State Text

Generic Loading

- Message: "Loading..."
- Use: Initial page load, data fetch

Specific Loading

- Message: "Loading incidents..."
- Use: When context is clear

Progress Loading

- Message: "Loading... 3 of 10"
- Use: When progress is known

Skeleton Text

Placeholder Text

- Format: Match actual content structure
- Length: Similar to real content
- Animation: Shimmer effect

Examples

- "Loading incident details..."
 - "Fetching data..."
 - "Processing request..."
-

Confirmation Messages

Standard Confirmations

Format: "Are you sure you want to [action] [entity]?"

Examples:

- "Are you sure you want to delete this incident?"
- "Are you sure you want to archive this release?"
- "Are you sure you want to resolve this ticket?"

Destructive Confirmations

Two-Step Confirmation

1. First: Standard confirmation dialog
2. Second: Type entity name or "DELETE"

Message Format: "Type '[entity name]' to confirm deletion."

Examples:

- "Type 'INC-2025-001' to confirm deletion."
- "Type 'DELETE' to permanently remove this incident."

Notification Messages

Toast Messages

Success

- Format: "[Action] [entity] successfully"
- Example: "Incident created successfully"

Error

- Format: "Failed to [action] [entity]. [Reason]"
- Example: "Failed to save incident. Please check your connection."

Warning

- Format: "[Warning message]. [Action]"
- Example: "Unsaved changes detected. Save before leaving?"

Info

- Format: "[Information message]"
- Example: "Export will begin shortly"

Inline Notifications

Alert Messages

- Format: Clear, actionable message
- Position: Top of page/section
- Dismissible: X button (if not critical)

Examples:

- "System maintenance scheduled for tonight at 2 AM."
- "New features available. Check the release notes."

Best Practices

Do

- ☒ Use clear, action-oriented language
- ☒ Provide context in error messages
- ☒ Use consistent terminology
- ☒ Format numbers and dates consistently
- ☒ Write helpful empty states
- ☒ Include actionable guidance

Don't

- ✗ Use technical jargon
 - ✗ Blame the user
 - ✗ Leave users without next steps
 - ✗ Use inconsistent formatting
 - ✗ Write vague error messages
 - ✗ Use casual or chatty tone
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Related:

- [Accessibility Standard](#)
- [Component Inventory](#)